



Weakened Hamas is softening its stances

Facing anger in Gaza, it offers key concessions in latest ceasefire talks

BY MIRIAM BERGER AND HAZEM BALOUSHA

RAMALLAH, WEST BANK — With its military power depleted and its political influence on the wane, Hamas is under growing public pressure to help bring the war in Gaza to an end.

Palestinians in the besieged enclave are desperate for a ceasefire after 14 months of conflict, and many residents said they are increasingly fed up with the militant group as they struggle to survive hunger, displacement and Israeli attacks. Last week, Hamas publicly softened its negotiating position with Israel.

A new proposal for a 60-day pause in hostilities and the exchange of Israeli hostages for Palestinian prisoners includes key concessions from Hamas, which relented on its demands for a complete halt to the war and the full withdrawal of Israeli forces, a Hamas official told The Washington Post. The group is still insisting that displaced Palestinians be allowed to return to northern Gaza, the official said, speaking on the condition of anonymity because he was not authorized to talk to the media.

As diplomats shuttle back and forth between Cairo and Doha, Qatar's capital, to discuss the proposal, Egypt has been working separately to broker a postwar Gaza governance agreement between Hamas and its rival Fatah party, which controls the Palestinian Authority in the occupied West Bank.

SEE HAMAS ON A14



BRIAN SNYDER/REUTERS

Donald Trump arrives at a news conference, his first as president-elect, where he previewed some policy shifts expected in his new term.

Bondi's legal role in 2020 complicates path to AG

False claims of fraud in Pa. likely to be examined in confirmation hearing

BY BETH REINHARD

On the morning of Nov. 4, 2020, former Florida attorney general Pam Bondi drove northeast from Washington to Philadelphia on an urgent mission: to monitor the tally of hundreds of thousands of mail-in ballots as President Don-

ald Trump's reelection hung in the balance.

Bondi and another Trump loyalist, Corey Lewandowski, quickly discovered that pandemic protocols were preventing Republican observers from closely scrutinizing ballots Trump had claimed were susceptible to fraud. So they called one of the president's most high-profile hired guns — former New York mayor Rudy Giuliani.

"I said, 'Gee Pam ... I don't have the time,'" Giuliani recalled to a D.C. Bar committee that later ruled that his election challenge in Pennsylvania was grounds for

disbarment. "I really didn't want to go because I had so many things to organize, and it seemed to me that just one jurisdiction wasn't worth sacrificing getting started in the others."

Giuliani was swayed to join Bondi, Lewandowski and Trump's younger son, Eric Trump, later that day at a news conference outside the Philadelphia airport, where Bondi declared: "We won Pennsylvania, and we want every vote to be counted in a fair way."

That appearance marked the beginning of Bondi's support for

Trump's efforts to undermine the 2020 election — a role often overlooked among the better-known players in the post-election drama but one documented in media reports, court filings, evidence obtained by the House committee that investigated the Jan. 6, 2021, riot at the U.S. Capitol, and testimony by Lewandowski and Giuliani during his D.C. disbarment proceeding.

Giuliani faced intense media

SEE BONDI ON A8

Threats within: Renewed focus on domestic terrorism could falter. **A7**

Trump steps into his new era

SIGNALS AN ABRUPT SHIFT FROM BIDEN

Discusses policy, pushes GOP on his Cabinet picks

BY MARIANNE LEVINE AND HANNAH KNOWLES

PALM BEACH, FLA. — President-elect Donald Trump, in a sweeping 70-minute news conference from his Florida home, signaled an abrupt shift from the Biden presidency in both substance and style, threatening to fire federal workers who do not return to the office and confirming that he is "looking at" privatizing the U.S. Postal Service.

Five weeks before Inauguration Day, Trump publicly embraced his role as president-in-waiting, mus-ing about issuing a pardon for New York's Democratic mayor and expressing skepticism about his daughter-in-law's chances of being appointed to replace Marco Rubio (R-Florida) in the Senate.

Trump also signaled that some Republican senators could face primary challenges for opposing his Cabinet picks if they were "un-reasonable." Overall, the president-elect signaled far greater comfort with the prospect of assuming power than he did eight years ago, boasting of the parade of business executives and foreign leaders who have visited him and bragging that he has already made progress on some of his goals.

Trump waded into the battle over some of his more controversial Cabinet picks, predicting that

SEE TRUMP ON A4

SoftBank: Appearing with Trump, CEO vows to invest \$100B in U.S. **A4**

Deny, delay: The practices fueling anger at insurers

Doctors say patients face increasing hurdles, often with little explanation

BY PETER WHORISKEY

After a UnitedHealthcare executive was gunned down on a New York City sidewalk, an eruption of bitter online commentary celebrated the killer's presumed motive: avenging the denial and delay of health insurance coverage.

Many spoke from personal experience. Every year, health insurance companies deny tens of millions of patient claims for medical expense reimbursements, and the tide of those denials has been rising, according to surveys of doctors and other health-care providers. Insurers also have been increasingly demanding that doctors obtain approval before providing treatment, similar surveys show, causing delays in patient care that the American Medical Association says are "devastating."

While several states have passed legislation trying to restrict such practices amid growing public anger, insurers defend the coverage denials and

SEE INSURANCE ON A19



ALLISON JOYCE FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Shawna Gilmore, a property manager and a real estate agent in Black Mountain, North Carolina, has fear and skepticism about how FEMA operates — feelings echoed by many other residents.

In N.C., FEMA distrust pervades

Misinformation, obstacles heighten hesitation to ask for help after Helene

BY BRIANNA SACKS AND KEVIN CROWE

SWANNANOVA, N.C. — Why, Shawna Gilmore thought, would she want to ask *them* for help? FEMA wasn't there right after Hurricane Helene all but destroyed her town. And a week or so later, when responders from the Federal Emergency Management Agency did show up, she became suspicious. An aerial video posted in one of her main Facebook groups showed trucks setting up what looked like some sort of camp. She said she kept hearing how FEMA "took things," like people's land.

"What are they actually doing here?" Gilmore said she thought to herself. "Why are they really here?"

This was not an agency that she said she wanted to give her personal information to, not even for a \$750 emergency check or other assistance. Beyond her "trust issue," she said, relying on the government for help isn't how she is built. The 54-year-old grew up in a rural southeast Missouri town right on the Mississippi River that frequently flooded, but they always picked themselves back up. Then she moved to this part of the Appalachian foothills about 30

SEE FEMA ON A10

Teen girl shoots, kills 2 at school in Wisconsin

15-year-old also injures six, then apparently dies of a self-inflicted wound

BY SARAH BLASKEY, HANNAH NATANSON AND TIM CRAIG

MADISON, WIS. — A 15-year-old girl shot and killed a fellow student and a teacher and wounded six other people at a small private Christian school on Monday, leaving a community reeling as another act of violence struck America.

The shooting at Abundant Life Christian School in the Wisconsin capital occurred shortly before 11 a.m. and was confined to a classroom in the K-12 school that was being used as a study hall, police said. At a late-night news conference Police Chief Shon Barnes identified the shooter as Natalie Rupnow, who he said went by the name Samantha.

Rupnow used a handgun and apparently died of a self-inflicted wound, Barnes said. Two students had "life-threatening" wounds, he said. None was identified.

The chief said the 911 call came from a second-grader: "I'm going to let that soak in for a minute: A second-grade student called 911 ... to report a shooting at school."

In news conferences through-

out the day, Barnes said investigators were trying to piece together a motive for the shooting.

Rupnow's parents were being questioned by police and were "fully cooperating," Barnes said.

Barnes and other city officials were visibly distraught as they spoke of the shooting.

"I think we can all agree that enough is enough," Barnes said. "We have to come together and do everything we can to support our students to prevent news conferences like these from happening again and again and again."

The school, which serves about 250 families, is tucked in a residential neighborhood in the eastern part of Madison. As word of the shooting spread, frantic parents began searching for their children, who had been evacuated from the school and sent to a reunification center.

The shooting occurred only two days after the 12th anniversary of the Sandy Hook Elementary School shooting in Newtown, Connecticut, in which 20 children and six adults died, making it the deadliest elementary school shooting in U.S. history.

On Monday afternoon, Wisconsin Gov. Tony Evers (D) and local officials in Madison and surrounding Dane County urged the public to pray for and comfort the Abundant Life Christian School community.

"There are no words to de-

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